

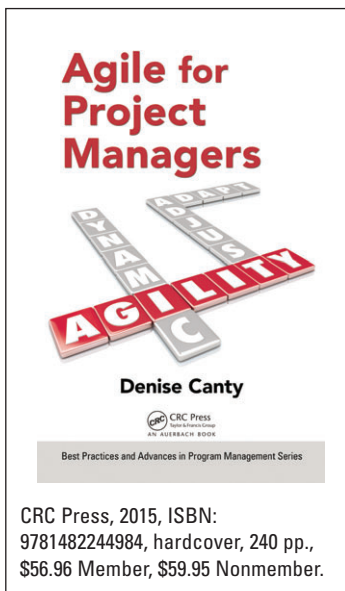
Agile for Project Managers

by Denise Canty

Agile software development has been around for decades, but its adoption by traditional project management was slow. Early in the 2000s, there were numerous articles and related debates about whether or not the pure agile approach for software development could coexist with PMI's *A Guide to the Project Management Body of Knowledge (PMBOK® Guide)*. In many circles, these two approaches were viewed as mutually exclusive. Of course, over time, this perception has greatly diminished and now project managers in the software development space are encouraged, if not expected, to be able to work on both sides of the fence.

Denise Canty's book helps guide project managers through their role when managing agile projects and teams. For instance, many project managers managing pure agile or the more commonly applied "agilistic" or adaptive projects are still required to plan out the overall project timeline, forecasting staffing requirements and total project budgets in a manner consistent with waterfall and traditional types of projects.

The book starts with an overview of some of the principles that are common to most agile projects, but from the point of view of a traditional project manager. Examples of such principles include that the agile approach is geared to delivering high-quality products that are value-focused. This is not to say that other more traditional project management approaches are not concerned with delivering quality products on time and in budget, but rather that the focus with agile is on the value delivery over process and documentation. The author also stresses that change and risk are inherent in an agile environment, which is in contrast to the typical project management approach of risk avoidance (or strongly controlled risk) and minimization of change. The key difference is in the acceptance of change and risk as part of the delivery process. This in turn, reshapes the project manager's role to be more adaptive in the application of traditional project



management processes in order to meet the demands of a continuously changing business environment.

One section that project managers might find particularly useful is Chapter 3, which compares and contrasts two of the most popular agile methodologies: Scrum and XP. This chapter provides an excellent overview for the novice agile project manager of two techniques that are often used concurrently. Additional agile methodologies are discussed later in the book (Chapter 17). Also, because agile is very team-centric, Canty addresses important topics such as stakeholder engagement (Chapter 5), people skills (Chapter 11), and the agile team concept (Chapter 12).

The author walks the reader through some of the typical tools (Chapter 4), documentation (Chapter 6), and types of tracking and reporting (Chapter 7) used when running an agile project. Chapter 8 provides

an excellent overview of the project management process as it applies to working on an agile project. Key to the agile approach is how the work is broken down. Requirements are gathered as user stories, then each user story is assigned a priority and a level of effort based on the team's capability and capacity. This composes the product backlog from which the team can do their release and sprint planning. The product backlog combined with the sprint retrospectives and current input from the business enable a more effective mechanism to effect change.

Most disciplines include some sort of professional certification and the agile world is no different. Chapter 13 provides a quick rundown of the more common industry certifications that are available to the agile practitioner. It should be noted that any certification is just the starting point, as it only documents that the holder has demonstrated an understanding of the principles related to that specific knowledge area. It is imperative for the holders of the certification to develop their expertise through actual application. Canty's book assists the traditional project manager in doing just that.